

specific month as well. Thorp seemed proud of his many achievements, but in a manner of satisfaction with a life well lived and without a trace of arrogance.



When you were growing up, did you have any idea where you were headed in life?

No. My father was very hostile to business. We suffered through the Great Depression. He was a security guard because that was the only work he could find. He was a soldier in World War I. He enlisted in time to be part of the American expeditionary force. He suffered multiple shrapnel wounds. Although he got a Purple Heart, Silver Star, and Bronze Star, he came back with a great hostility toward war based on what he had seen. A lot of my father's attitudes rubbed off on me, including the pain and suffering of the Depression and an aversion to war, unless it is what you call a necessary war.

Was your father an educated man?

He was. He had about a year and a half of college, but unfortunately didn't have the money to continue. He was really smart, though. He had a natural math ability. So did my mother. He also was a very good writer. It didn't amount to much, but he won a writing contest in Chicago and got a typewriter in 1934. I wrote an elementary probability book on the same typewriter in 1965.

I got interested in science when I was eight or nine. I went to an academically deficient high school. I think we ranked 31 out of 32 in the LA school system. So I basically taught myself. I set up a laboratory behind the garage in a laundry room that I shared with my mother. I bought chemicals with the money I made delivering newspapers at 2 A.M. I was interested in physics, chemistry, astronomy, and electronics, and I had a grand time learning all these things. My intention was to go to college to become an academic scientist, most likely a chemist. I was averse to business because I bought into my father's point of view that it was full of thieves who didn't have the best interests of the world in mind and were after whatever they could get.